

3 MYA ▶ 8000 BCE



The earliest musical instruments found are flutes more than 40,000 years old, made out of bird bones and mammoth ivory.

790,000 BCE

First use of fire

Human ancestors may have known how to make and control fire as far back as 1.5 million years ago. The earliest traces of domestic fire are hearths at the site of Gesher Benot Ya'aqov in Israel, dating from 790,000 BCE. With fire, people could cook and eat a wider range of foods.

400,000 BCE

Hunting with spears

Around this date, early hunters began to use wooden sticks as spears. These tools had sharpened ends and could be thrust or thrown, which meant prey could be targeted from greater distances. By about 200,000 BCE, stone points were added to the spears, making them more effective.

The oldest-known wooden spears were found at Schöningen, Germany.



Early hunter aims his spear



3 MYA

400,000

125,000

c 2.6 MYA–250,000 BCE STONE TOOLS

The first objects known to have been purpose-made by our ancestors were stone tools. The oldest, from Lake Turkana in Kenya, date back 3.3 million years. The toolmakers used one stone to strike small flakes off another stone, creating a sharp cutting edge. Tools made in this way are described as "Oldowan."

Handaxes

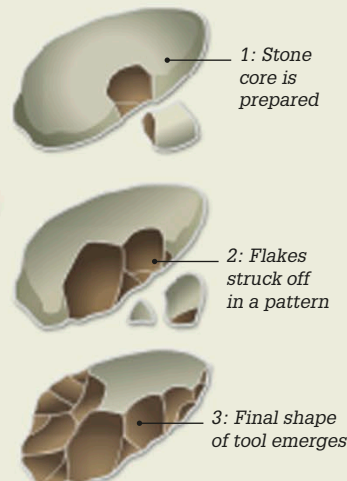
The Oldowan stone tools were fairly crude. Then, around 1.76 million years ago, a new method of working stone appeared. Known as Acheulean, it involved flaking off two sides of the stone to create a double edge, and shaping the bottom to make it easy to grip. Such tools are called handaxes.



Oldowan cutting tool



Acheulean handaxe



Levallois technique

Around 325,000 years ago, stoneworkers started using a tool-making technique, now known as Levallois. In this, they cut flake tools in a deliberate pattern from a stone core.

71,000 BCE

Bows and arrows

Small stone arrowheads found in South Africa show that humans had learned how to make bows and arrows by 71,000 BCE. Such weapons were more efficient than spears. A person could carry many arrows on a hunt and bring down prey at long range.



Early arrowhead